

STRATEGIC DOCUMENT

Civic Project for Peace and Reconciliation

SILA

An Independent Civic Space for Peace, Reconciliation and
Co-Construction
between Moroccans and Sahrawis Returning from Tindouf

ANALYSIS AND DRAFTING TEAM

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Available in: Arabic · French · English · Spanish

About this Document

This document is the final output of a long path of analytical and field work led since 2018 by **SweFOR — Swedish Fellowship of Reconciliation**, a Swedish organization specialised in peacebuilding and conflict resolution, which has accompanied over the years successive Maghrebi youth groups (Morocco, Algeria, Tunisia, Western Sahara, Mauritania).

This document was produced by the current Moroccan group as part of its closing workshops. Its work coincided with **the diplomatic turning point on the Sahara file in 2025** (UN Security Council Resolution 2797, around 120 states backing the autonomy plan, Algerian repositioning). This coincidence made it possible — for the first time — to move from theoretical analysis to **an operational, field-ready project proposal** that responds to the present moment and prepares for it together.

WHY NOW?

We start from the conviction that **the next phase of the Sahara file will not be political but societal**. When the political agreement is signed, politics will be over — but the real human work will only just have begun. This document is a call to start that work **before the signature**, not after.

Methodology

The group adopted the « **From Theory to Practice** » methodology grounded in the Reflecting on Peace Practice (RPP) and Strategic Nonviolent Action and Peacebuilding (SNAP) frameworks of the United States Institute of Peace (USIP).

1. 3 Boxes analysis
2. Curle Diagram
3. RPP Matrix
4. Theory of Change

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Context of the Problem

Before any analysis, the reader must grasp the historical and diplomatic framework of the Sahara dossier to understand why the present moment compels Moroccan civil society to intervene with a reconciliation and co-construction project.

1.1 — Historical Background

Before 1975 — The Spanish Colonial Period

The territory has been a Spanish colony under the name "Spanish Sahara" since 1884. The Sahrawi population consists mainly of nomadic tribes bound by cross-border kinship networks (Rguibat, Tekna, Ouled Delim) — links that still exist today and form the social foundation of any future reconciliation project.

1975 — The Pivotal Year

- **October 1975:** The International Court of Justice issues its advisory opinion. It recognizes ties of allegiance between certain Sahrawi tribes and Moroccan sultans, but concludes these do not constitute a territorial sovereignty annulling the Sahrawi people's right to self-determination.
- **6 November 1975:** King Hassan II launches the Green March — 350,000 Moroccan civilians enter the territory peacefully.
- **14 November 1975:** The Madrid Tripartite Accords — Spain hands over administration of the territory to Morocco (two northern thirds) and Mauritania (southern third).
- **27 February 1976:** The day after the last Spanish soldier's withdrawal, the Polisario proclaims the "Sahrawi Arab Democratic Republic" in Bir Lahlou. War breaks out immediately, and tens of thousands of Sahrawis move toward the Tindouf area in Algeria.

1976 - 1991 — The War Phase

An asymmetric war between the Moroccan army and the Polisario, militarily and financially backed by Algeria and Gaddafi's Libya. Mauritania withdraws from the conflict in 1979; Morocco regains the

remaining disputed territories. In the 1980s, Morocco builds a 2,700 km defensive wall to limit Polisario attacks.

1991 — Ceasefire and MINURSO

The UN secures a ceasefire and establishes MINURSO. Stated mission: organize a self-determination referendum. **This referendum has never taken place**, due to an intractable disagreement on the voter list.

2007 — Moroccan Autonomy Plan

Morocco presents its autonomy plan: the territory would become an autonomous region with parliament, government, and local administration, under Moroccan sovereignty.

2020 — US Recognition

The United States of America recognizes Moroccan sovereignty over the Sahara — the first permanent member of the Security Council to do so. This recognition marked a major diplomatic turning point that prepared what followed at the international level.

1.2 — Latest Developments (2022 - 2026)

The diplomatic dynamic has clearly tilted in Morocco's favor since 2022, with strong acceleration after Security Council Resolution 2797.

Date	Event
March 2022	Spain (the historical colonial power) officially supports the Moroccan autonomy plan.
October 2024	The French President declares before the Moroccan Parliament that "the present and future of the Sahara fall within the framework of Moroccan sovereignty".
June 2025	The United Kingdom joins the pro-autonomy camp, describing the plan as "the most credible basis".
October 2025	Security Council Resolution 2797 : 11 votes in favor, Algeria did not participate. The resolution explicitly refocuses negotiations on the Moroccan autonomy plan.
November 2025	Algeria surprisingly proposes to "mediate" between Morocco and the Polisario — signal of repositioning.
February 2026	Madrid talks between Morocco, Algeria, and the Polisario under US sponsorship. Morocco presents an expanded version of the autonomy plan (~40 pages).
March 2026	US senators introduce a "Polisario Front Terrorist Designation Act" in Congress.
April 2026	Mali suspends its recognition of the SADR and backs the Moroccan plan.

IN SUMMARY

Roughly **120 states** support the Moroccan plan. The Security Council is refocusing negotiations on that basis. Algeria is hinting at mediation. Mali withdraws its recognition. The window of opportunity is open — and it is essentially open now.

SECTION 2

Methodology

This document adopts the « **From Theory to Practice** » methodology, grounded in the *Reflecting on Peace Practice* (RPP) and *Strategic Nonviolent Action and Peacebuilding* (SNAP) frameworks of the **United States Institute of Peace** (USIP).

It comprises four integrated tools, applied sequentially:

#	Tool	Function	Expected Output
1	3 Boxes	Sort information about the conflict: peace-driving forces, key actors, conflict-driving forces.	Structural understanding.
2	Curle Diagram	Identify the current phase of the conflict on the transformation curve and choose the appropriate intervention.	Temporal positioning.
3	RPP Matrix	Position activities on a 2×2 matrix by target audience and change level.	Balanced intervention strategy.
4	Theory of Change	Articulate causal hypotheses as "If we do X, it will lead to Y because...".	Testable program logic.

FOUNDING PRINCIPLE

It is not enough to identify actors and factors; one must understand the **relationships and dynamics** between them and how they evolve. Good analysis is explanatory and predictive, not merely descriptive.

SECTION 3

Step 1 — 3 Boxes Analysis

Sorting information on the Sahara file into three columns: peace-driving forces, key actors, and conflict-driving forces. Goal: *clarity, not completeness.*

Peace-driving forces (to mobilize)	Key actors	Conflict-driving forces (to neutralize)
• Equity and Reconciliation Commission (IER 2004-2005): unique Arab precedent. • The post-2797 royal speech: a "return" frame rather than "forced integration". • Cross-border kinship ties: families separated for 50 years, same tribes (Rguibat, Tekna, Ouled Delim). • Shared Hassani dialect. • Maliki Islam and Sufi orders. • 2015 Advanced Regionalization: legal framework ready. • Economic boom of Moroccan Sahara: Dakhla port, solar energy, phosphates — real job opportunities. • Moroccan diplomatic strength: support of USA, France, Spain, UK, and over 120 states. • Morocco's political and institutional stability: among the most stable in Africa.	• King Mohammed VI: moral + religious + political authority. • Former Polisario cadres who have returned. • Sahrawi women on both sides. • Traditional tribal sheikhs. • Sahrawi diaspora in Spain. • Youth 18-30 (primary target group). • National Human Rights Council. • Moroccan universities and research centers.	• Polisario military elite in Tindouf: will lose influence and privileges — maximum resistance expected. • Algerian military intelligence. • Moroccan conservatives who may view returnees as "rewarded traitors". • "Historical" Sahrawis in Morocco: risk of identity-based jealousy. • International organizations supporting the separation of regions and the breakup of states, active in Europe and South Africa. • Intergenerational trauma: 50 years of hostile family narrative. • Tindouf's rent-economy of conflict. • Risk of violent extremism from some returnees: for some, accepting autonomy could be a pretext to access Moroccan territory and carry out violent acts, even far from the Sahara. This risk was repeatedly and explicitly flagged by the Sahrawi participants themselves during the analytical process of the project.

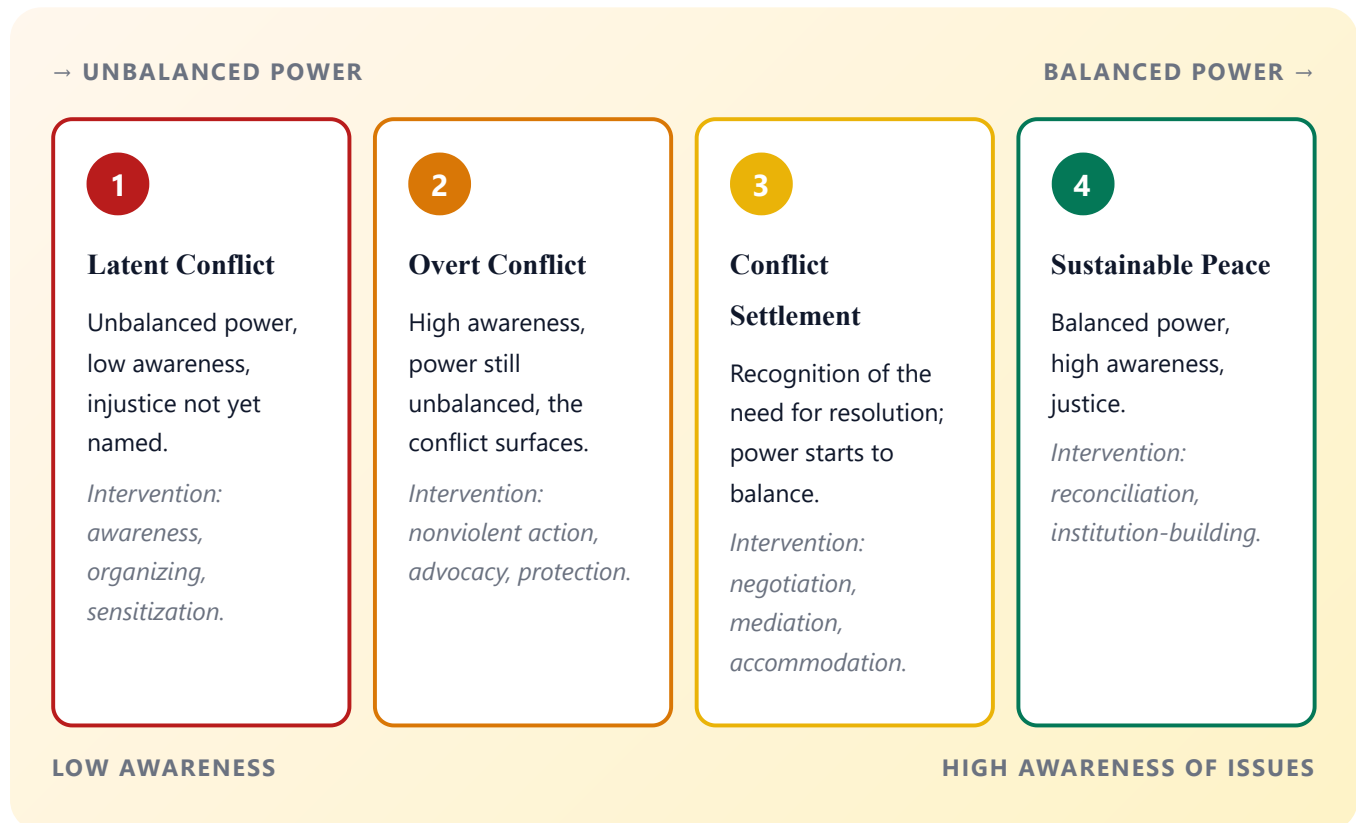
Key Driving Factors

From the 3 Boxes analysis emerge **five pivotal factors** that ground the project:

- 1 The level of **trust** Tindouf youth feel toward the Moroccan project.
- 2 The capacity to offer **economic dignity** to returnees (not charity, but status).
- 3 The size of symbolic space left for a distinct Sahrawi identity (language, culture, memory).
- 4 The visibility and credibility of returned "memory holders".
- 5 The level of protection against political and media instrumentalization, and against security infiltration.

Step 2 — Curle Diagram

Adam Curle's model maps the path from latent conflict to sustainable peace through **four phases**, along two axes: awareness of issues (horizontal) and balance of power (vertical).



Diagnosis: Phase Mismatch Between Parties

Each party to the conflict is living in a different phase of the curve. Understanding this mismatch is what makes intervention design precise:

Party	Phase	What it needs
Tindouf residents	1 → 2	Awareness that the world has changed, presentation of alternatives, opening information windows.
Returnees / prospective returnees	2 → 3	Accompaniment in the transition, protection of dignity, gradual integration.
Moroccans of the South and North	3 → 4	Framing of reconciliation, avoid revenge discourse, equitable welcome.
Former Polisario cadres	3 → 4	Status, visibility, legitimization of "memory holder" role.

Step 3 — RPP Matrix

The RPP matrix forces us to place each activity into one of four cells produced by the crossing of two dimensions:

- **Target audience:** Key people (decision-makers, leaders, institutional actors) vs. More people (broader public, youth, families).
- **Change level:** Individual / Personal (values, knowledge, behavior) vs. Socio-political (institutions, policies, structures).

	Key People (Decision-makers)	More People (Broader Public)
Individual Change	KI — Cell 1: individual change in key people a1 Public testimonies from returned former Polisario cadres. — <i>Curle 3 → 4</i> a2 Training tribal sheikhs to reopen cross-border ties. — <i>Curle 1 → 2</i>	MI — Cell 2: individual change in more people a3 Hassani-language digital content (TikTok, YouTube, podcast) → Tindouf youth. — <i>Curle 1 → 2</i> a4 Individual case-work cell (legal, employment, housing, psychological) for returnees. — <i>Curle 2 → 3</i> a5 Hassani cultural caravans and an academic program on shared memory. — <i>Curle 3 → 4</i>
Socio-political Change	KS — Cell 3: socio-political change in key people a6 Welcome Charter signed by CNDH, universities, and local authorities. — <i>Curle 3 → 4</i> a7 Parliamentary advocacy for a "Dignified Return" legal framework. — <i>Curle 3 → 4</i> a8 Legal framework and one-stop "Dignified Return" desk: civic status, diploma equivalence for ex-Polisario cadres, property restitution, schooling, ID card, social security. — <i>Curle 3 → 4</i>	MS — Cell 4: socio-political change in more people a9 Trilingual media platform (Hassani / Darija / Spanish). — <i>Curle 2 → 3</i> a10 Sila Centre in Tan-Tan or Guelmim (structured civic space, independent of the State). — <i>Curle 3 → 4</i> a11 Economic integration program for returnees (grants, micro-credit, Dakhla partnerships). — <i>Curle 3 → 4</i>

KI

Key × Individual — Key people × individual change

KS

Key × Socio-political — Key people × socio-political change

MI

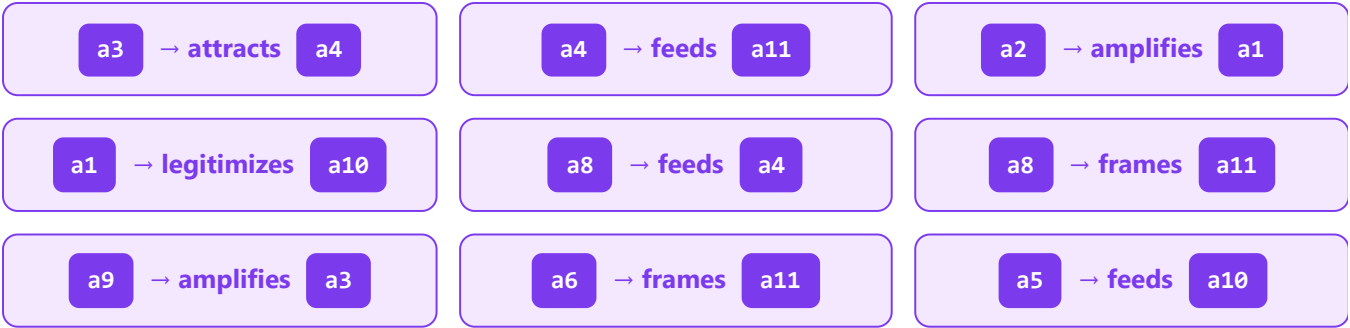
More × Individual — More people × individual change

MS

More × Socio-political — More people × socio-political change

Causal Relationships Between Activities

How activities chain to produce cumulative effects:



Verification of the 3 RPP Criteria

CRITERION 1 — VALIDATED

Not staying in a single cell: the strategy covers all four cells (Cell 1: 2 activities, Cell 2: 3 activities, Cell 3: 3 activities, Cell 4: 3 activities).

CRITERION 2 — VALIDATED

Linking individual change to socio-political change: arrows a4 → a11 (individual case-work leads to structural economic integration), a1 → a10 (testimonies lead to the Centre), a5 → a10 (cultural programs lead to infrastructure).

CRITERION 3 — VALIDATED

At the socio-political level, **reaching key people AND more people together:** Cell 3 (CNDH charter, parliamentary advocacy, "Dignified Return" desk) and Cell 4 (media, Centre, economic integration) with effective bridges between them (a6 → a11, a8 → a11).

Step 4 — Theory of Change

We test the causal hypotheses underpinning the strategy using the formula: "*If we do [X], it will lead to [Y] because [causal mechanism]*". On two levels: macro (global hypothesis) and micro (per-activity hypothesis).

Macro Level — Global Project Hypothesis

IF WE ACCOMPLISH

an independent civic space for peace, reconciliation, and co-construction between Moroccans and Sahrawis returned from Tindouf, operational and recognized, functioning during the post-settlement phase.

THEN IT WILL LEAD TO

a dignified and participatory coexistence between returning Sahrawis, Moroccan Sahrawis, and Moroccans — with Sahrawi identity preserved, memory acknowledged, mobility secured, and violent extremism prevented.

BECAUSE

1. The institutional settlement is taking shape (Resolution 2797, around 120 states) but social absorption has not been prepared — without it, the solution remains administrative and never becomes human.
2. The IER 2004-2005 experience proved that Moroccan truth-and-reconciliation commissions work, and that civil society is more credible than the State for this work.
3. The Curle phase mismatch (Tindouf at phase 1-2, institutions at phase 3-4) creates a risk of post-settlement crisis if nothing is done.
4. The cross-border fabric (kinship, Hassani, Maliki Islam, tribes) is a latent social capital that no one else can activate — not the State (suspected), not the UN (external), not the Polisario (compromised).
5. Sahrawi participants themselves have explicitly voiced the possibility of resorting to violence and war to undermine settlement outcomes — making social and security preparation a duty, not a choice.

Micro Level — Hypothesis per Pivot Activity

TC1 — Digital Content

MEDIUM CONFIDENCE

IF

we publish Hassani-language digital content targeting youth 18-30 in Tindouf (a3).

THEN

alternative narratives will reach those who choose to seek them inside the camps, opening information windows for those who are ready.

BECAUSE

the goal is not to convince everyone — most will not move. The goal is to ensure that those who genuinely question or hesitate find alternative material rather than an information vacuum. Even very limited impact is enough to create a current of would-be individual returnees.

⚠ RISK

if Algerian intelligence detects and blocks the accounts, or if opponents use them to launch "Moroccan propaganda" accusations pushing hesitants toward hardening.

TC2 — Individual Case-work Cell

HIGH CONFIDENCE

IF

we set up an individual case-work cell (legal, employment, housing, psychological) for returnees (a4).

THEN

returnees will experience the return as dignified and stable, creating a reassuring precedent for those who follow.

BECAUSE

early returnees serve as a social signal; their experience spreads rapidly through family networks between Tindouf and Moroccan Sahara. A positive experience is more powerful than any official communication.

⚠ RISK

if resources are insufficient or accompaniment shallow, the effect reverses: those rejecting return use the first cases as counter-evidence.

IF

we publish a Welcome Charter signed by the CNDH, universities, and local authorities (a6) + parliamentary advocacy for the "Dignified Return" framework (a7).

THEN

dignified return will have an explicit and enforceable legal and institutional framework.

BECAUSE

the IER 2004-2005 experience demonstrated that formal signed charters create a standard that local actors cannot circumvent.

⚠ RISK

if signature is purely symbolic without follow-up mechanism, the charter becomes a dead letter.

IF

we open the Sila Centre in Tan-Tan or Guelmim with public testimonies (a10).

THEN

both sides' memories will be acknowledged and archived, without hierarchy.

BECAUSE

public archiving of narratives changes the conflict's nature: it shifts from living memory (unstable) to institutional memory (stable, shared). A core mechanism of any post-conflict reconciliation.

⚠ RISK

if the Centre is perceived as a State arm, skeptical Sahrawis will refuse to testify. Institutional independence is a sine qua non condition.

TC5 — Security Early-Warning Mechanism

LOW CONFIDENCE (BUT NECESSARY)

IF

we set up an early-warning mechanism in partnership with trusted Sahrawi leaders, to detect signs of violent extremism among returnees, alongside credible economic alternatives.

THEN

the risk of violent extremism will be detected early and neutralized, without collective stigmatization or boomerang effect.

BECAUSE

repeated warnings from Sahrawi participants themselves — over eight years of SweFOR workshops, the last one included — confirm that some opponents **"will not be at peace until they see blood"**. Sahrawi peers are the only reliable observers of that current.

⚠ RISK

infiltration of the mechanism exposes innocent Sahrawis to unfair accusations. Overbroadening the definition of "extremism" can lead to political criminalization. The mechanism must remain narrow, operational, and independent.

Conclusion and Recommendations

After applying the four steps, this document concludes with five strategic convictions:

1 · The Window Is Open Now

The diplomatic dynamic has clearly tilted in Morocco's favor, but social absorption of the solution has not been prepared. Every month that passes without preparing the human and social ground is an irrecoverable loss.

2 · Sila Is the Bridge Between Diplomacy and Humanity

Without this bridge, the solution remains administrative and never becomes human. A political agreement without a social foundation eventually explodes years later — that is what every post-conflict experience of the last century teaches.

3 · Institutional Independence Is a Sine Qua Non

If the project is perceived as a State communications arm, it dies in front of Sahrawis. **The project's strength is its civic nature, not its closeness to power.**

4 · The Security Risk Is Real and Documented

The warning that some opponents may use autonomy as a pretext to access Moroccan territory and carry out violent acts, even far from the Sahara (Rabat, Casablanca and others), has been repeated explicitly by **the Sahrawi participants themselves** over eight years of workshops. The early-warning mechanism **is not optional, it is an existential necessity for the project.**

5 · The Real Work Begins After Signature

Politics will be over. Reconciliation of people will take 20 years, and no one other than Moroccan civil society is positioned to carry it out credibly.

Operational Recommendations

- 1 Secure independent and diversified funding (the Moroccan State must not be the sole funder).
- 2 Choose the Centre's geographic location (Tan-Tan or Guelmim — a historically neutral interaction zone).
- 3 Draft an ethical charter for the project: no appropriation, no victory narrative, parity in speech.
- 4 Build partnerships with the CNDH, universities, and local authorities.
- 5 Set up the early-warning mechanism.
- 6 Launch Phase 0 (field preparation, 12 months): mapping separated families, testimonies bank, preliminary partnerships.
- 7 Adopt cautious language: no "victory", no "end", but "the beginning of a new phase".

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Sila — Strategic Document

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